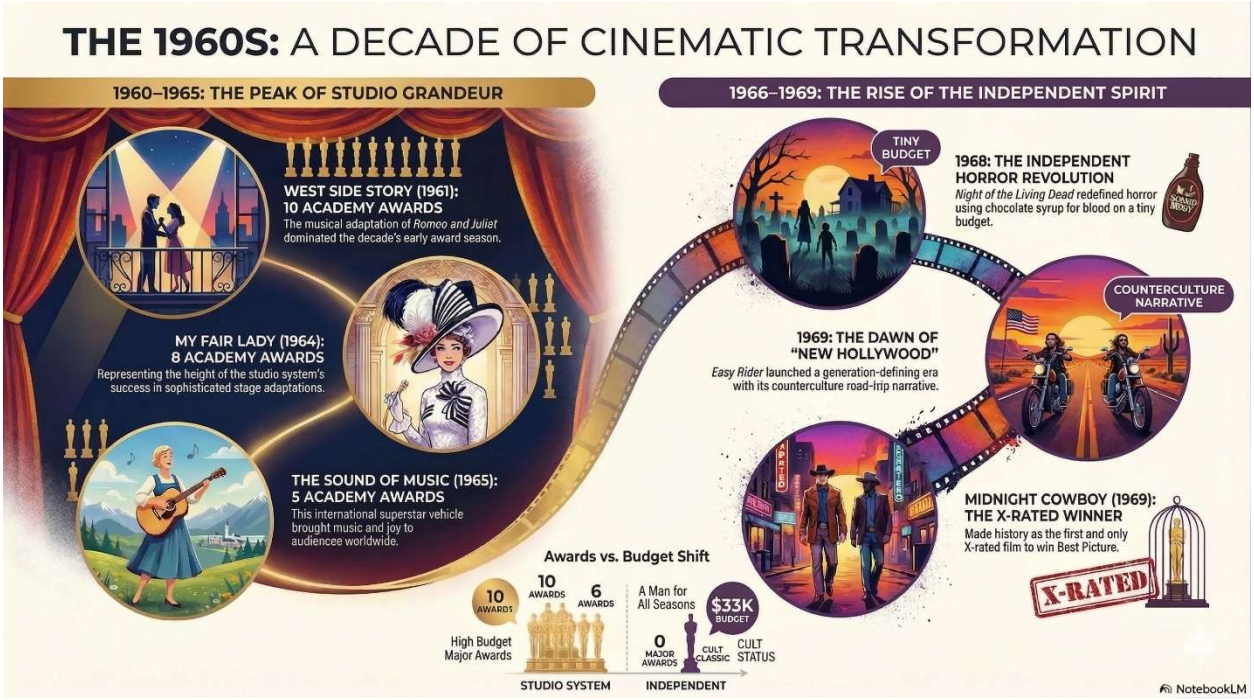
The 1960s Cinematic Shift from Studio Epics to Gritty Independent Films



Introduction

The 1960s was a transformative decade for cinema, bridging the gap between the classic studio system and the gritty, realistic dawn of the New Hollywood era. The following document provides a comprehensive overview of this pivotal cinematic period. It includes detailed breakdowns of major Academy Award winners and groundbreaking independent films, highlighting their plots, key characters, and fascinating behind the scenes trivia. Additionally, it features brief biographies of the visionary directors and iconic actors who helped define the silver screen during this unforgettable decade.

Psycho (1960)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Anthony Perkins, Janet Leigh, Vera Miles, John Gavin
- Top Director: Alfred Hitchcock
- Plot: A Phoenix secretary steals $40,000 from her employer to run away with her boyfriend, but her journey is violently interrupted when she checks into a remote motel managed by a young man under the strict domination of his mother.
- Characters: Norman Bates (Anthony Perkins), Marion Crane (Janet Leigh), Lila Crane (Vera Miles), Sam Loomis (John Gavin)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Netflix, Max, and Roku. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Google Play, and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Hitchcock bought the rights to the original novel anonymously for just $9,000. He then bought up as many copies of the book as he could find to keep the ending a secret from the public before the film was released.
- Awards: Four Academy Award nominations. Golden Globe win for Best Supporting Actress (Janet Leigh).
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_FMkGEZP3w0

The Apartment (1960)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Jack Lemmon, Shirley MacLaine, Fred MacMurray
- Top Director: Billy Wilder
- Plot: An ambitious insurance clerk tries to climb the corporate ladder by lending out his apartment key to his superiors for their

extramarital affairs, but things get complicated when he falls for the elevator operator his boss is seeing.

- Characters: C.C. Baxter (Jack Lemmon), Fran Kubelik (Shirley MacLaine), Jeff Sheldrake (Fred MacMurray)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Netflix, MGM+, and TCM. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Apple TV, and Roku.
- Unusual Tidbits: Director Billy Wilder and co-writer I.A.L. Diamond were strict about their script, forcing multiple takes for missed words, but allowed Lemmon to improvise the scene where he strains spaghetti through a tennis racket.
- Awards: Five Academy Awards, including Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Original Screenplay.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Yfq1FaSxvNw

West Side Story (1961)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Natalie Wood, Richard Beymer, Rita Moreno, George Chakiris
- Top Directors: Robert Wise and Jerome Robbins
- Plot: Two youngsters from rival New York City gangs fall in love, but tensions between their respective friends build toward tragedy in this sweeping musical adaptation of Romeo and Juliet.
- Characters: Maria (Natalie Wood), Tony (Richard Beymer), Anita (Rita Moreno), Bernardo (George Chakiris)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Prime Video, Netflix, and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Jerome Robbins was fired before production wrapped for pushing the film over budget with retakes, though he still won Best Director alongside Wise.

- Awards: Ten Academy Awards, including Best Picture, Best Director, Best Supporting Actor, and Best Supporting Actress.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1PWpP8priK0

Carnival of Souls (1962) - Independent

- Top Actors and Actresses: Candace Hilligoss, Frances Feist, Sidney Berger
- Top Director: Herk Harvey
- Plot: After miraculously surviving a car plunging off a bridge, a young church organist moves to a new city. She soon finds herself stalked by a ghostly figure and inexplicably drawn to an abandoned lakeside pavilion.
- Characters: Mary Henry (Candace Hilligoss), Mrs. Thomas (Frances Feist), John Linden (Sidney Berger)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Max, Criterion Channel, and free on Tubi, Pluto TV, and YouTube.
- Unusual Tidbits: Director Herk Harvey was primarily a producer of educational and industrial films and shot the entire feature on a budget of just $33,000 after driving past the abandoned Saltair pavilion in Utah.
- Awards: No major awards at the time of release, but it has since been recognized as a cult classic.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MnfDXhM7-80

Lawrence of Arabia (1962)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Peter OToole, Alec Guinness, Anthony Quinn, Omar Sharif

- Top Director: David Lean
- Plot: A complex British Army officer is sent to Arabia during World War I to act as a liaison between the Arabs and the British. He eventually unites rival tribes to lead a guerrilla campaign against the Turks.
- Characters: T.E. Lawrence (Peter OToole), Prince Faisal (Alec Guinness), Auda abu Tayi (Anthony Quinn), Sherif Ali (Omar Sharif)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Criterion Channel. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Google Play, and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Peter OToole disliked the severe discomfort of riding a camel, so he bought a piece of sponge rubber to pad his saddle, a trick the Bedouin extras quickly adopted.
- Awards: Seven Academy Awards, including Best Picture and Best Director.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t_V-h55jRY

Tom Jones (1963)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Albert Finney, Susannah York, Hugh Griffith
- Top Director: Tony Richardson
- Plot: In 18th-century England, a charming and handsome adopted son of a wealthy squire wenches his bawdy way through various misadventures as he tries to make his fortune and win the heart of a wellborn local woman.
- Characters: Tom Jones (Albert Finney), Sophie Western (Susannah York), Squire Western (Hugh Griffith)

- Where to Find It: Streaming on Max and The Criterion Channel. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Director Tony Richardsons 1989 directors cut of the film is actually seven minutes shorter than the original theatrical cut.
- Awards: Four Academy Awards, including Best Picture and Best Director.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=B_p3jKiHQKI

My Fair Lady (1964)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Audrey Hepburn, Rex Harrison, Stanley Holloway
- Top Director: George Cukor
- Plot: An elitist and arrogant phonetics professor places a wager that he can take a working-class Cockney flower vendor and make her presentable in high society simply by teaching her how to speak with an upper-class accent.
- Characters: Eliza Doolittle (Audrey Hepburn), Professor Henry Higgins (Rex Harrison), Alfred P. Doolittle (Stanley Holloway)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Netflix. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Apple TV, and Roku.
- Unusual Tidbits: Famous ghost singer Marni Nixon dubbed almost all of Audrey Hepburns vocal performances because Hepburns singing was deemed not strong enough.
- Awards: Eight Academy Awards, including Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Actor.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=l8SfagD69zw

The Sound of Music (1965)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Julie Andrews, Christopher Plummer, Eleanor Parker
- Top Director: Robert Wise
- Plot: A young novitiate is sent by her convent in 1930s Austria to become a governess to the seven children of a widowed naval officer. She brings music and joy back into their lives as the looming shadow of World War II threatens their homeland.
- Characters: Maria (Julie Andrews), Captain von Trapp (Christopher Plummer), The Baroness (Eleanor Parker)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Disney Plus. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Google Play, and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Christopher Plummer notoriously disliked the movie during its production, often referring to it on set as The Sound of Mucus, though he softened his stance considerably in his later years.
- Awards: Five Academy Awards, including Best Picture and Best Director.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XuaiJr3gVbU

A Man for All Seasons (1966)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Paul Scofield, Wendy Hiller, Leo McKern, Robert Shaw
- Top Director: Fred Zinnemann
- Plot: Sir Thomas More, the Chancellor of England, remains true to his Catholic principles and refuses to endorse King Henry VIIIs wish to divorce Catherine of Aragon in order to marry Anne Boleyn, leading to a tragic clash of wills.

- Characters: Sir Thomas More (Paul Scofield), Alice More (Wendy Hiller), Thomas Cromwell (Leo McKern), King Henry VIII (Robert Shaw)
- Where to Find It: Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Apple TV, and Google Play.
- Unusual Tidbits: Shot on a relatively small budget of just 2 million dollars, its incredible critical success brought in significant box office returns.
- Awards: Six Academy Awards, including Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Actor.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=q_TRKC44C78

The Good, the Bad and the Ugly (1966)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Clint Eastwood, Eli Wallach, Lee Van Cleef
- Top Director: Sergio Leone
- Plot: During the American Civil War, two men form an uneasy, shifting alliance against a ruthless third mercenary in a frantic race to find a fortune in Confederate gold buried in a remote cemetery.
- Characters: Blondie (Clint Eastwood), Tuco (Eli Wallach), Angel Eyes (Lee Van Cleef)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Netflix and free on Tubi. Available to rent or buy on Apple TV, Prime Video, and Google Play.
- Unusual Tidbits: Eli Wallach was nearly killed three times during filming, including an instance where a train almost severed his head.
- Awards: No major US awards at the time, though it is now widely considered one of the greatest Westerns ever made.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v555nCIY_E8

In the Heat of the Night (1967)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Sidney Poitier, Rod Steiger, Warren Oates, Lee Grant
- Top Director: Norman Jewison
- Plot: A Black Philadelphia police detective is mistakenly arrested for murder while passing through a small, racist Mississippi town. After his innocence is proven, he is begrudgingly asked by the local police chief to help solve the crime.
- Characters: Virgil Tibbs (Sidney Poitier), Chief Bill Gillespie (Rod Steiger), Officer Sam Wood (Warren Oates), Mrs. Leslie Colbert (Lee Grant)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Max, MGM+, and free on Pluto TV. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Sidney Poitier insisted the film be shot in the North due to past harassment in the South. Most location shooting occurred in Illinois.
- Awards: Five Academy Awards, including Best Picture and Best Actor.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=LxP4kwXb6Ro

2001: A Space Odyssey (1968)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Keir Dullea, Gary Lockwood, William Sylvester
- Top Director: Stanley Kubrick
- Plot: After discovering a mysterious, artificially created monolith buried beneath the Lunar surface, humanity sets off on a quest to Jupiter with the help of an advanced and increasingly unpredictable supercomputer.

- Characters: Dr. Dave Bowman (Keir Dullea), Dr. Frank Poole (Gary Lockwood), Dr. Heywood R. Floyd (William Sylvester), HAL 9000 (Douglas Rain)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Max and free on Sling Freestream. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Google Play, and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: To create the illusion of a floating pen in zero-gravity, Kubrick used double-sided tape to stick a pen to a large sheet of glass and slowly rotated it in front of the camera lens.
- Awards: One Academy Award for Best Special Visual Effects.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bz6xD3xQiT8

Night of the Living Dead (1968) - Independent

- Top Actors and Actresses: Duane Jones, Judith O'Dea, Karl Hardman
- Top Director: George A. Romero
- Plot: A diverse group of strangers barricade themselves in a rural Pennsylvania farmhouse to survive the night as reanimated corpses with an insatiable hunger for human flesh surround the property.
- Characters: Ben (Duane Jones), Barbra (Judith O'Dea), Harry Cooper (Karl Hardman)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Max, Peacock, and free on Tubi and Pluto TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: The filmmakers used Bosco chocolate syrup for blood because it looked darker and more realistic on black and white film.
- Awards: No major awards upon release, but selected by the Library of Congress for preservation in the National Film Registry in 1999.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DOrEjWjOTnE

Oliver! (1968)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Mark Lester, Ron Moody, Shani Wallis, Oliver Reed, Jack Wild
- Top Director: Carol Reed
- Plot: A musical adaptation of the classic Charles Dickens novel about an orphan who escapes a bleak workhouse and falls in with a gang of young pickpockets operating on the streets of 19th-century London.
- Characters: Oliver Twist (Mark Lester), Fagin (Ron Moody), Nancy (Shani Wallis), Bill Sikes (Oliver Reed), The Artful Dodger (Jack Wild)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on Prime Video. Available to rent or buy on Apple TV and Google Play.
- Unusual Tidbits: Director Carol Reed was the uncle of actor Oliver Reed, who played the villain Bill Sikes.
- Awards: Five Academy Awards, including Best Picture and Best Director, plus one Honorary Award for choreography.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lLtvVsvDREs

Easy Rider (1969) - Independent

- Top Actors and Actresses: Peter Fonda, Dennis Hopper, Jack Nicholson
- Top Director: Dennis Hopper
- Plot: Two counterculture bikers travel from Los Angeles to New Orleans carrying the proceeds of a drug deal. Along the way, they encounter the changing landscapes and deep cultural divides of America.
- Characters: Wyatt (Peter Fonda), Billy (Dennis Hopper), George Hanson (Jack Nicholson)

- Where to Find It: Available to rent or buy on Prime Video, Google Play, and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: Most of the dialogue was improvised, and its massive success helped launch the New Hollywood era of filmmaking.
- Awards: Cannes Film Festival Award for Best First Work. Two Academy Award nominations.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=B6I-AjAWmkM

Midnight Cowboy (1969)

- Top Actors and Actresses: Jon Voight, Dustin Hoffman, Sylvia Miles
- Top Director: John Schlesinger
- Plot: A naive Texas dishwasher moves to New York City with dreams of becoming a highly paid gigolo for wealthy women, but he ends up struggling to survive on the streets alongside an ailing con man.
- Characters: Joe Buck (Jon Voight), Enrico Ratso Rizzo (Dustin Hoffman), Cass (Sylvia Miles)
- Where to Find It: Streaming on MGM+, and free on Tubi and Pluto TV. Available to rent or buy on Prime Video and Apple TV.
- Unusual Tidbits: This film made history as the first and only X-rated movie to win the Academy Award for Best Picture, though it was eventually re-rated to an R.
- Awards: Three Academy Awards, including Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Adapted Screenplay.
- Video Analysis: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-WYcaZVv23w

Biographies of Top Directors

- Alfred Hitchcock: Known as the Master of Suspense, he directed over 50 feature films and pioneered many crucial techniques in the psychological thriller genre.
- Billy Wilder: An Austrian born American filmmaker who became one of the most versatile and brilliant writers and directors of Hollywoods golden age.
- Robert Wise: An Academy Award winning director and producer known for his immense versatility across genres, from science fiction to sweeping musicals.
- Herk Harvey (Independent): A director and producer primarily of educational films who made his lasting mark on cinema with his lone feature film, Carnival of Souls.
- David Lean: An English film director known for his large scale epics and meticulous attention to visual detail and sweeping landscapes.
- George Cukor: A legendary Hollywood director celebrated for his sophisticated comedies and skillful adaptations of famous stage plays.
- Sergio Leone: An Italian film director who pioneered the Spaghetti Western genre, known for his extreme close ups and lengthy, tension filled scenes.
- Norman Jewison: A Canadian film director and producer whose films often addressed controversial social and political issues.
- Stanley Kubrick: A visionary American film director renowned for his intense perfectionism, visual brilliance, and dark humor across various genres.

- George A. Romero (Independent): An American filmmaker who revolutionized the horror genre by creating the modern zombie movie with Night of the Living Dead.
- Carol Reed: An acclaimed English film director best known for his atmospheric thrillers and successful transition into big budget musicals.
- Dennis Hopper (Independent): An American actor and filmmaker whose rebellious spirit helped usher in the New Hollywood era of the 1970s.
- John Schlesinger: An English film and stage director known for his gritty, realistic portrayals of complex human relationships on screen.

Biographies of Top Actors and Actresses

- Anthony Perkins: An American actor best remembered for his iconic and chilling portrayal of motel proprietor Norman Bates.
- Janet Leigh: An American actress and author who became one of Hollywoods biggest stars in the 1950s and 1960s, immortalized by her role in Psycho.
- Jack Lemmon: A highly acclaimed American actor known for his extraordinary ability to balance manic comedy with deep dramatic pathos.
- Shirley MacLaine: An American actress, singer, and dancer known for her quirky charm and versatile performances in both comedies and dramas.
- Natalie Wood: A former child star who successfully transitioned into complex adult roles, becoming one of the most prominent actresses of her era.

- Candace Hilligoss (Independent): An American stage actress who achieved cult status for her haunting lead performance in the low budget thriller Carnival of Souls.
- Peter OToole: A highly trained British stage actor whose magnetic screen presence made him a global superstar after playing T.E. Lawrence.
- Audrey Hepburn: A British actress and humanitarian recognized as a film and fashion icon, known for her elegance and charm.
- Julie Andrews: An English actress and singer who became an international superstar with her legendary performances in classic movie musicals.
- Clint Eastwood: An American actor and filmmaker who rose to international fame as the stoic Man with No Name in Italian Westerns.
- Sidney Poitier: A Bahamian and American actor who broke racial barriers in Hollywood and became the first Black actor to win the Academy Award for Best Actor.
- Keir Dullea: An American actor best known for his remarkably restrained and enduring role as the astronaut Dr. Dave Bowman.
- Duane Jones (Independent): An American actor and theater director who made history as the first Black actor to star as the lead hero in a horror film.
- Peter Fonda (Independent): An American actor and counterculture icon who co-wrote, produced, and starred in the generation defining road movie Easy Rider.
- Dustin Hoffman: An American actor known for his meticulous preparation and his ability to completely transform into deeply flawed, unconventional characters.

- Jon Voight: An American actor who rose to prominence in the late 1960s with his critically acclaimed portrayal of a naive Texas street hustler.

Conclusion

The cinematic achievements of the 1960s continue to influence modern filmmaking in countless ways. By studying these classic studio productions alongside the daring independent films of the era, you can see the profound evolution of storytelling, character development, and visual artistry. Whether you are analyzing the meticulous pacing of a suspense thriller, the sweeping scale of a historical epic, or the raw energy of a counterculture road trip, the lessons from these timeless films remain just as relevant today.

Discussion Questions

Storytelling and Pacing

- How does the pacing in a suspenseful film like Psycho compare to the sweeping, episodic narrative structure of an epic like Lawrence of Arabia?
- What techniques do the screenwriters and directors use to build tension without relying heavily on dialogue, such as in the climax of The Good, the Bad and the Ugly?

Character Arcs and Development

- In what ways do the deeply flawed protagonists in Midnight Cowboy and The Apartment challenge the traditional hero archetype that was common in earlier Hollywood films?
- How does the use of an ensemble cast in West Side Story allow the filmmakers to explore multiple perspectives on the same central conflict?

Production Constraints and Creativity

- How did the severe budget limitations of independent films like Night of the Living Dead and Carnival of Souls force the directors to make more inventive storytelling choices?
- When comparing the practical visual effects in 2001: A Space Odyssey to modern techniques, how does the physical reality of the props impact the immersion in the story?

Cultural Impact and Shifts

- How does Easy Rider reflect the changing cultural landscape and the deep societal divides of late 1960s America?
- In what ways did the transition from the strict studio system to the New Hollywood era change the types of stories that could be told on screen?